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Beyond the House of Hunger: Democratic Struggle in Zimbabwe

Brian Raftopoulos

In 1980, after more than a decade of armed liberation struggle, ZANU-PF took power in Zimbabwe. The new government under President Mugabe became increasingly repressive, seeking to force opposition either into alliance with ZANU, or into silence. This authoritarian process appeared to be culminating in a formal one-party presidentialist state, de facto one-party rule having being achieved in the late 1980s. This article describes the process and analyses growing opposition to it, both from within ZANU and from groupings within civil society — notably students, workers, peasant communities, and the petty bourgeoisie. In part one (which appeared in ROAPE 54, July 1992), the role of the petty bourgeoisie is examined, especially its private sector component. Part two below describes and interprets peasant discontent and worker opposition.

Land, Labour and the Popular Classes

Historically, the labour movement in Zimbabwe has been weak, and characterised by divisions on racial lines; sectionalism; low national density; political factionalism; and elitist and undemocratic structures (Wood, 1988). After independence, workers used the new environment to vent their accumulated anger at the wage levels, discriminatory practices and repressive labour dispute mechanisms inherited from the colonial period. The strikes – around 200 in all – also indicated the levels of expectations and the very real will for change amongst workers. The labour movement, plagued by its legacy of problems, could not fully connect with the rhythm and intensity of the strikes. The workers themselves concentrated on the immediate issues, with little or no long-term conceptions of their actions, which were thus largely short-term and defensive. The State's goals were to end the strikes, resume production levels, establish communication links with the workforce, and reassure employers that while eager to rectify the injustices suffered by labour, it was in no mood to undermine the settler colonial relations of production. Thus while workers were able to exploit the temporary receptiveness of the State to labour issues, this receptiveness was always ambivalent.

As the divisions and lack of centralised authority of the unions became more evident and the employers recovered from their initial defensive stance, the

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changing balance of forces produced less than sympathetic State responses. The use of the State's coercive machinery against striking workers characterised its commitment to gradual reformist labour policies within existing production structures. Accusations have been made against 'selfish' and 'irresponsible' workers, whose role in the struggle has been questioned, and whose 'privileged' position vis-a-vis the peasantry has been invoked. For the labour movement the task of becoming more effective has centred around three issues: developing autonomy from the State while remaining able to use it to advance the interest of labour; developing broader alliances with other sections of the popular classes; and mobilising membership from the workplace by providing effective union leadership on issues affecting workers.

The Zimbabwe Congress of Trade Unions (ZCTU) was initiated by ZANU (PF) in 1980, to create a central trade union amenable to a corporatist solution to labour issues. Before this, five trade union centres had already combined to form the United Trade Unions of Zimbabwe (UTUZ), which failed to gain recognition from the new State, which was reluctant to have to deal with a labour confederation formed independently of the State and whose political affiliations were more towards ZAPU and ZANU (Sithole). Despite vigorous protests, the labour movement proved too weak and divided along regional and political lines to prevent the formation of the new centre.

During the early and mid-1980s, the imposed leadership of the trade union struggled for credibility amongst workers. Moreover, its lack of a democratic base and dependence on outside funding, compounded by the State's delay in the introduction of a check-off system, led its members into a series of corrupt practices. The State's disdainful attitude was clearly shown by its failure to allocate any of the 20 seats formerly reserved for whites to representatives of the labour movement. It felt strong enough to dismiss labour to the sidelines, 'speak' for the labour movement annually through the announcement of the minimum wage and through the Labour Relations Act, and to make strikes effectively unlawful.

By the late 1980s relations between the State and the labour movement began to change. The latter, having removed the more corrupt elements in its leadership, also applied itself more carefully to democratic accountability. Moreover, cracks in the State's attempted corporate strategy were becoming apparent. While minimum wage legislation has improved the purchasing power of agricultural and domestic employees, for workers in commerce and industry the minimum wages, at 1989 prices, have dropped to 13% below their 1980 purchasing power level. This decline, however, must be assessed along with the phenomenal increase in social expenditure since 1980. Significantly, the drop in purchasing power has also affected the professional groups such as nurses and teachers, who in 1990 conducted the longest strikes in post-independence labour history. Along with other urban groups, these professionals have also suffered from the housing and transport crisis and the escalating

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cost of living.

The growth of union activity in the public sector reflects the expansion of employment in public administration, education and health, from 128,200 in 1980 to 220,300 in 1989. Moreover, public sector unionism has not been significant hitherto in the overall labour movement, largely because under existing legislation trade unions have not been allowed to exist in this sector. However, the erosion of professional status and earning power has been an important recruiter of these sections of the labour force to union activity. While there is definitely an opportunity for the growth of a broader labour movement composed of a wide cross-section of occupational groups pushing at the very least for more welfarist policies, there is however the danger, and in the short-term the more likely prospect of professional workers supporting more individualist programmes promising the return of elite status and greater social mobility. The support of sections of the professionals for ZUM thus had more to do with bread and butter issues than opposition to a one-party state. Such a development could cause further divisions in the labour movement, particularly given the inability of the current industrialisation process to create large numbers of jobs in the formal sector.

The autonomy of the ZCTU has been further demonstrated by the increasingly critical position of the movement on economic and political issues. It criticised the new Investment Code in 1989 claiming that it demonstrated 'much more pertinently than ever the government's avowed commitment to capitalism', and attacked the government's structural adjustment programme at the May Day 1991 celebrations, saying it would increase the hardships of the poor. On the political level, the movement has criticised government's response to the student movement's struggle against corruption and the one-party state. Links between the student and labour movements have begun to grow, although they still remain tenuous.

The labour movement has grown in stature and independence. ZCTU now has 29 affiliates with a membership of about 200,000; with the Organisation of Collective Cooperatives of Zimbabwe (membership 250,000), unionised labour amounts to almost half a million. The State now cultivates its support; ZANU (PF) tried to persuade the movement to back it in the 1990 elections, and one of the ZCTU vice-presidents was appointed Deputy Minister of Labour, Manpower Planning and Social Welfare after the election. For the most part, however, the movement has resisted this recent attempt at cooptation, with ZCTU declaring its neutrality in the elections. As the corporatist strategy has crumbled, the new adjustment programme, with its attendant liberalisation of labour relations, has led to an emphasis by the State on attempting to control unions through the market mechanism. It remains to be seen how effectively the unions will be able to operate under these conditions.

The labour movement has made important strides over the last ten years, but still faces enormous problems in mobilisation, organisation and engaging in

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the process, with other classes, of challenging the structural adjustment orthodoxy. Peta and others' recent study of five unions in Zimbabwe noted that:

> *half of the number of workers we interviewed did not know anything about unions at all. Of the other half, many of them were members of the union some time in the past but resigned because they said they no longer had confidence in the union, or that the unions are powerless, or that they were useless anyway.*

Unions continue to face obstacles such as lack of education of members and leaders, and a serious inadequacy of means of communication to develop a public sphere through which working people may come to recognise themselves, their problems and their common interests. Moreover the SAP is presenting labour with increasing problems. In addition to the increasing threats of retrenchment, plummeting real wage levels, deregulations of labour laws, decontrol of prices, removal of subsidies and the implementation of cost-recovery measures in health and education, the labour movement also has to face a State ready to use coercive measures now that its corporatist strategy has broken down.

Thus in a recent strike by semi-skilled railway workers for higher wages, the employer dismissed 4,000 workers, and the State suspended the operations of their union, ZARU, appointing the Zimbabwe Transport Union Federation to act as an agent union representing the members of the suspended body. Although, after negotiations, most of those dismissed were reinstated, the episode indicated the State's intolerance of what it considers widespread 'worker indiscipline', which could result in a major collision with ZCTU still struggling to develop its autonomy. The strike also displayed divisions in the workforce, between the more craft based artisan unions seeking to fight for their own interests outside the more general unions dominated by the semi-skilled and unskilled workers. This trend has already been apparent in other parastatals and could grow under the increasingly defensive conditions of SAP. Finally, the State's use of the Transport Union Federation to split the unions over the strike exemplified the differential relationship of unions to the State. Such factors are likely to present the central union body with serious strategic problems.

However, one of the most fundamental issues that will determine the trajectory of the labour movement will be its ability to deal with the rural-urban linkages of the labour force, and hence the land question. The cumulative effects of land expropriation, labour migration and changed cropping systems have made the wage relation a critical factor in the survival of rural households. In ensuring food security, such households have been forced to rely on diversified income sources, especially remittances from urban wage employment. Urban wage earners, faced with low wages, inadequate pensions and welfare payments, and a risk of unemployment, maintain their access to land as some guarantee against unemployment, old age and retirement. A fundamental aspect both of the cost of reproduction of labour power and of the mobilisation of labour thus relates to the land question. The leadership of the

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labour movement may now be taking the rural-urban alliance more seriously, and linking such an alliance to future political strategy. Secretary-General Tsvangirai of the ZCTU observed in an interview that:

> *The workers will always have a role, since they are the producers. They should not advocate workerism because 80 per cent of our population are peasants. What they should do is to try and link up workers and peasants into strong structures to advance their interests. That's the only way we can draw the ruling party away from the right wing and convert it to our own purpose.*

This statement expressed very clearly the labour movement's dual strategy of establishing an autonomous presence while wringing as many concessions as possible from the State and ruling party.

This raises the problem of worker consciousness. In both the liberal and certain strands of the radical historiographic traditions, the grand trajectory of proletarianisation and progress has raised the 'modernist spectre of backwardness' when discussing rural linkages. Cheater's critique of such models in the Zimbabwean context, though ending up in a retreat into relativism, does make important points about the problems of applying linear models of proletarianisation to Zimbabwean workers. For any strategy to successfully mobilise 'workers-peasants' the idea of placing such producers on a linear continuum of consciousness will have to be shelved. As Ferguson has warned, it is the complex reality between the 'stick figures' of migrant labourer and permanent urbanite that needs to be understood more clearly. It is this reality that raises major strategic and organisational problems not only for the labour movement in Zimbabwe but for any force on the left envisaging a peasant worker alliance.

Democratisation and the Land

While the legitimacy of the ruling party has been eroded among the petty-bourgeoisie and labour in the urban areas, its rural support has remained relatively strong, consolidated through measures designed to improve the livelihood of the rural population. These included rural resettlement; a rapid expansion of education and health facilities; provision of extension, credit and marketing services; and an expansion roads and of water supplies linked to a policy of growth points and district service centres. The land question remains however a fundamental problem in Zimbabwe.

At present land is distributed thus: large-scale commercial farmers 1.5m hectares; small-scale commercial farmers 1.5m; communal area farmers 16m; and resettlement land brought by the government 3.9m. This represents a fall in the per centage of land controlled by commercial farming, including settler farmers and multinational-owned agro-industries, from 42% in 1980 to 29% in 1989. The resettlement programme has been relatively limited, with targets being reduced, and only some 51,000 families being resettled in 1982-88. Support for communal area farmers, has led to high increases in production, but

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has also accelerated the process of differentiation. To a great extent, poor and middle peasants are forced into selling their labour power, as they face extreme pressures in meeting the reproduction costs of the family from their own subsistence production. Women face the brunt of this hardship, for while they constitute the majority of the communal farmers, few have powers with regard to land use rights. For the majority of communal area farmers, land productivity for most crops and livestock remains well below the level attained by large-scale commercial farmers and less than 25% of such farmers have contributed to the increased performance.

It is clear, therefore, that agrarian policy for the majority producers has been confined to an incremental set of measures, defining the land question largely in terms of resettlement and increases in State services. The concern with continuity of production and the need for foreign exchange, so often argued by white communal farmers, has kept attention focused on immediate balance of payments problems rather than long-term structural considerations

Continuing hardships, inequalities on the land and escalating unemployment brought the land question to the fore once again through the Constitution of Zimbabwe Amendment (No.11) Bill of December 1990. The Bill gives the State extensive powers to acquire land in local currency, at a price determined by principles of compensation specified by Parliament. Initially, the Bill was aggressively advocated by the Minister of Lands, Agriculture and Rural Resettlement in a series of blunt confrontations with commercial farmers. At one such meeting he informed them that:

> *The responsibility of this Government is to get land and give it to the landless. We will go ahead with this programme . . . and the status quo where vast fertile tracts of land are owned by the few individuals will not continue.*

There seems little reason to believe that the State will move substantially beyond its existing policy of gradually supporting small black farmers, cooperatives and State farms without risking major falls in production, employment and exports in the established white-dominated commercial sector. Four factors support this argument. The SAP places primary emphasis on production for export and foreign currency earnings, and the State is highly unlikely to depart from this trajectory. State and Party officials have been purchasing land in increasing numbers, with one estimate placing the number of commercial farms owned by blacks at a figure of 300. Recently, emergent black commercial farmers stated their intention to form a separate organisation to press for their own interests. Given these developments, serious land redistribution may soon run counter to the interests of these groups except insofar as such redistribution increases their own land ownership. There are indications from the various farming bodies, and signals from the State, that any future reform must be less concerned with need than with proven farming ability. Finally, no new financial impetus for land reform was given in the 1991-92 Budget, with only Z$15 million allocated for land acquisition, and Z$22 million for infrastructure development of resettlement areas. It remains to be seen

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how far the government utilises accumulation from the healthier parts of the economy to stimulate growth in the underdeveloped sectors. Moreover, this is not just a technical question of resource transfers, but relates to the balance of social forces within the country and their capacity to organise for the mobilisation of resources in their interests.

Also important is the lack of organised pressure from the bulk of the peasantry not represented by existing farmers' organisations. The post-1980 years saw the breakdown of war-time mobilisation and local committees and the concentration of government energy on the implementation of top-down initiatives in local government. Rural and District Councils are heavily dependent on central grants and decision-making. VIDCOs and WADCOs intended to become vehicles for active participation and involvement remain an insignificant part of the planning process. Peasant responses where they have occurred thus far have tended to be localised and under the hegemony of an elite-led national organisation or planning machinery. Where the State's provision of social services has failed, NGOs have tapped into the needs of peasants and in many cases initiated their own agenda. Squatters have sometimes been able to overrule a minimal State presence in certain areas, and peasants have been able to impose their demands, at certain times and with the backing of Party leaders. However, this kind of intervention has not been unambiguous, sometimes concealing the patronage of aspiring politicians and the accumulative manoeuvrings of aspiring entrepreneurs.

Finally, the course of producer and marketing cooperatives has been littered with obstacles. Yash Tandon expressed the central fallacies in the State's perception of collective cooperatives. He has criticised both the planning model that subordinates the human factor to the demands of production, and the expectation that cooperatives would simply follow the production experience of large-scale commercial farms without taking into account the peasant demands and the current realities of Zimbabwe's agrarian problem. As a result, members of the collectives have become labourers, much as on capitalist farms, in conditions of low productivity and income levels, and their morale has been seriously affected. Many members regard the farms as the property of the government, with their real interests concentrated on the two to four acres of land given to each on the farm.

Against such odds the constraints facing the majority of rural producers are formidable. Cliffe is correct when he writes that, supported by the struggles of urban workers, peasants in Zimbabwe 'can only look to the small but significant minority of radicalised politicians and civil servants who are still seeking to act out some of the democratic and liberating aspirations of the nationalist struggle'. It must also be acknowledged, however, that as the resettlement programme reaches a levelling off in terms of production gains, pressures on the land are likely to produce other interest groups amongst the peasantry. The forms of opposition that could result from such pressures is a complex issue, relating to the complexity of land demands being pursued. Demands

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could range from landless, mainly young, households seeking communal area land allocations, to black urban and rural-based elites seeking freehold title to land in growth point areas, on to commercial farms seeking to retain land rights. We must wait to see the responses arising from such differential demands.

Conclusion

Whatever attempts are made at radical transformation in Zimbabwe will, to a significant extent, depend on the determinate factor of external pressures from international capitalist relations. While domestic political movements will attempt to negotiate problems between desirable objectives and the constraints of 'feasibility', the pressures from international capital will continue to be applied in order to ensure conditions under which the only 'feasible' option is a deepening structural integration into the international division of labour. Serious efforts to ensure national sovereignty over decision-making will have to confront the lethal effects of these corrosive pressures. The 1980s witnessed the destructive onslaught of neo-classical theory in the malevolent form of structural adjustment. To obtain the necessary international finance, developing countries have been forced into a long-term debt servicing burden from which they have no chance of extricating themselves. Out of the attempted implementation of these doctrinal distortions, African countries have on the whole emerged weakened, in the sense that the latter have increasingly lost their sovereignty over the determination of national policies. There is no reason to believe that Zimbabwe's fate with structural adjustment will be any different. Moreover, the collapse of stalinism has given more legitimacy to those forces, national and international, who have been trying to 'kill the dream' of radical alternatives in southern Africa.

While any perceptions of Zimbabwe's future must be punctuated with question marks, the most realistic picture to present must be based on a critical assessment of the existing social forces in the country and their relation to the international balance of forces. From the above analysis of the Zimbabwean situation it is fair to say that, as elsewhere on the continent, even as objective conditions cry out for a radical democratic denouement, the popular forces remain relatively weak. However, there are also indications of a strengthening of certain popular organisations, like the labour movement, and the potential for radicalisation of sections of the petty-bourgeoisie, as eroding economic conditions present increasing dilemmas about the future. Yet a most problematic aspect of the equation remains the party that will lead the necessarily harsh and lengthy battle against capital in Zimbabwe. ZANU (PF) remains the dominant party force in the country, and at present there are no viable alternatives to the left of the political spectrum. Moreover, it is not even clear what such an alternative force could be expected to carry out under the present constraining conditions, in the country and within the region. As matters stand there have been increasing signs of the rightward drift of the ruling

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party. The 'left' within the Party as well as outside of it has grown increasingly isolated, and without an opposite pole of attraction. Yet it is also clear that there are strong dissenting voices within the Party on the question of democratisation. However, at present the centre-right drift of the Party seems more likely to continue into the near future. These are pessimistic times for the grand narratives of socialism, which have rightly come under critical scrutiny. Nevertheless, there is a vacuum in terms of alternatives, into which imperialism, an unfashionable word, continues in its current mood of triumphs, to press its own disastrous imperatives for the future. In the darker visions of the omniscience of imperialism it has often seemed that there is no significant role for African interventions, and that all the continent appears to do is to plug into international circuits. It has never been easier to slip into such a fatalistic position as at present. Yet imperialism has never been such a totalising presence, and African interventions have played their role in the dramatic changes of our dramatised century, not least in the struggle for Zimbabwe. It is, therefore, with an embattled optimism that the future needs to be faced.

Brian Raftopoulos works at the Zimbabwe Institute of Development Studies; he wishes to thank his colleagues Lloyd Sachikonye and Sam Moyo for valuable comments on this article.

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Errata — 'Social Differentiation in the Communal Lands of Zimbabwe' by Cousins, Weiner and Amin published in ROAPE 53. The Editorial Working Group recognises that cuts were made to this article which changed the sense of their argument. This was due both to last minute changes by the authors and unapproved cuts by the editors. We do apologise and publish their comments:

1. Awkward or misleading omissions: the introduction is considerably shorter and reads somewhat awkwardly. A sentence stating that: 'In the paper, we draw implicitly on recent historical research that is of relevance' was originally followed by references to the work of Mosley, Ranger, Dopcke, Bessant and Phimister; these references now appear in the published text following a sentence referring to analysis of 'the social relations of production and exchange'. This is potentially confusing, as is the footnote which refers to a section in a previous draft of the article discussing this historical research at some length. A sentence on page 15 referring to rural prostitution as 'one mechanism whereby cash circulates from men to women' was omitted and this paragraph now reads awkwardly. In the final paragraph the phrase 'democratic agrarian property regime' was replaced by 'democratic regime'; clearly these are two different meanings.

2. Deletion of qualifying statements: a number of statements were deleted which make is clear that we approach the issues of class mobility and class politics rather cautiously, acknowledge the possibility of local variations and contingent outcomes, and are aiming to initiate a debate. Missing from the conclusion on page 19 is the statement: 'The following is necessarily an impressionistic judgement, given the uneven nature of the available data base and recognising the existence of local variations unique to particular places. The class categories identified in this paper, and the tendencies outlined below, are presented as hypotheses for further investigation rather than as firm research conclusions. We offer the following as a preliminary statement to generate additional discussion on the nature of Communal Land social differentiation.'

3. A paragraph describing the work of Pankhurst on gender and class relations in Zimbabwe was omitted from the text. The only major source in the article now dealing with these issues is the work of Adams; this significantly weakens both the literature review and our attempt to highlight these relationships throughout the text. The deletion on page 15 makes the text read as if the ideas which follow are our own rather than being drawn from the work of these two authors.

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